Wilhelm Radloff — Proben der Volkslitteratur der türkischen Stämme (1866–1907)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Wilhelm Radloff (1837–1918), the great Siberian Turkologist, who spent four decades building the *Proben der Volkslitteratur der türkischen Stämme*, ten volumes published at St. Petersburg between 1866 and 1907. They are counted in this dossier among the first systematic treatments of Central Asiatic ethnography, and each part was issued with the original texts together with Radloff's own German translation. One famous slice, the *Manas* material, reached English readers in A. T. Hatto's editions, while the other nine-tenths remain without an English translation found after research. The dedication honours the patience of the whole undertaking, tribe by tribe and volume by volume.

The story

Wilhelm Radloff — Vasily Radlov (1837–1918) — is described in the record as the great Siberian Turkologist, a scholar of the Turkic languages and peoples of Siberia and Central Asia. Over four decades he built a collection of folk literature on a scale few scholars attempt.

The *Proben der Volkslitteratur der türkischen Stämme* — “Examples of the Folk Literature of the Turkic Tribes” — appeared in ten volumes at St. Petersburg

between 1866 and 1907. The dossier counts them among the first systematic treatments of Central Asiatic ethnography, the study of peoples and their customs. Each part was issued in two forms together: a volume of the original texts, and a volume giving Radloff's German translation.

Some parts are landmarks in their own right. Part V, published in 1885, is the Kyrgyz volume, and it contains Radloff's *Manas* texts — material from the Kyrgyz epic tradition. Part VI, published in 1886, is the Taranchi volume; the Taranchi are identified in the dossier as Uyghur. Part VIII, published in 1899, contains Ignác Kúnos's Ottoman material.

The collection as a whole has reached English only in one famous slice. The other nine-tenths — the record's own proportion — remain, on the findings here, without an English translation found after research. A work built tribe by tribe and volume by volume survives in full, with its author's own German translations facing the original texts, waiting for an English form that has not yet been made.

The work and what survives

Radloff died in 1918, and all ten volumes were published between 1866 and 1907. They are in the public domain in the United States.

Full PDFs are available on Wikimedia Commons, from Google Books and HathiTrust sources. Two examples are pinned in the record: Part VI, 291 pages, published in 1886, and Part VIII, 652 pages, published in 1899.

The shape of the original publication helps any future translator. Because each part appeared both as original text and as Radloff's German translation, the German volumes stand beside the Turkic texts as the author's own guide to their meaning.

Its English fortunes

Only the *Manas* slice has modern English, and that English is in copyright. A. T. Hatto's *The Manas of Wilhelm Radloff* was published by Harrassowitz in 1990, and his *Memorial Feast for Kökötöy-Khan* was published by Oxford University Press in 1997.

The bounded finding for the rest is this: no English translation of the other nine-tenths of the *Proben* — the South Siberian, Taranchi, Ottoman, Kazakh, and other

tribal volumes — found after research.

That distinction is kept exact. The *Manas* material has distinguished modern English editions, and they are in copyright. Their existence does not supply English for the remaining volumes, and this dossier does not treat it as doing so.

What completing it would take

Completing it would proceed volume by volume, working from Radloff's own facing German translation, with the Turkic text alongside. The German is described in the record as a built-in crib — the author's own translation, present from the start to guide the new one.

Part I, on the South Siberian tribes, published in 1866, is the natural first unit. The record notes that it has the same shape as the Miladinov and Afanasyev work elsewhere in this survey: a defined opening volume, taken on its own, before the larger collection is attempted as a whole.

Sources

- https://www.britannica.com/topic/Proben-der-Volkslitteratur-der-turkischen-Stamme
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- https://edblogs.columbia.edu/worldepics/epic-theory-practice-history/ (Hatto's *Manas* volumes)